SALIM SAIDY

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PERSONAL PROFILE

Development economist and doctoral researcher specializing in financial inclusion, FinTech, labour markets, and applied financial-sector research. Trained in applied mathematics and economics, with experience designing and delivering empirical research using econometrics, causal machine learning, and computational text analysis. Current doctoral research examines the drivers, resilience, and distributional effects of digital financial inclusion across Sub-Saharan Africa and the developing world. Research also examines occupational mobility, digital transformation, and labour-market inclusion. Author or co-author of five peer-reviewed journal articles and three book chapters, and a member of HUMAN-IT - COST Action 24167, Working Group 3.

METHODS AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Econometrics and Causal Inference:** Panel data models, panel cointegration, fixed effects, difference-in- differences and event studies, Double Machine Learning, causal forests, bootstrap and simulation-based inference.
- **Machine Learning and Text Analytics:** Double Machine Learning, Causal Forests, gradient boosting (XGBoost, LightGBM, CatBoost), cross-validation, SHAP, transformer-based (BERT-family) sentiment classification, BERTopic topic modelling, and consumer-review analysis.
- **Programming and Software:** Expert: Python, Stata, and EViews. Proficient: R, MATLAB, SPSS, SmartPLS, and Microsoft Office. Additional analytical software: GAUSS.
- **Data Management:** Survey and administrative microdata, cross-country panel construction, large-scale web and API data collection, data cleaning, reproducible workflows, and research-quality assurance.

PROFESSIONAL AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Doctoral Researcher | September 2023 - Present

Department of Economics, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey

- Conduct empirical research on financial inclusion, FinTech adoption, financial resilience, institutional quality, capital markets, labour markets, and household economic outcomes using survey, panel, and cross-country data.
- Develop Turkish-language computational text-analysis pipelines using transformer-based (BERT-family) sentiment classification, BERTopic topic modelling, and explainable machine learning to analyse large-scale consumer-generated digital data.
- Apply causal and predictive methods including Double Machine Learning, causal forests, fixed-effects and event- study designs, panel estimators, XGBoost, LightGBM, CatBoost, random forests, and SHAP-based interpretation.
- Managed analytical projects end to end, including research design, large-scale data acquisition and cleaning (240,000+ observations), estimation, diagnostics, validation and reporting.
- Produce peer-reviewed and policy-oriented research linking empirical evidence to questions of financial access, institutional performance, and economic development and resilience.

Graduate Teaching Assistant/Fellow | September 2021- June 2025

Department of Economics, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey

- Taught and supported undergraduate and graduate instruction in applied econometrics, macroeconomics, and microeconomics.
- Guided and reviewed the analytical work of the students, including model specification, software implementation, and interpretation of results.
- Performed all other duties assigned by the respective professor.

Director of Strategic Communications and Marketing (Volunteer) | November 2022 – October 2026

African Youth Architects, Rabat, Banjul, and New York

- Lead a multi-country communications team and coordinate strategic communication, task allocation, quality assurance, and organizational positioning.

President of African Affairs (Volunteer) | May 2022- July 2023
New World Foundation (Yeni Dünya Vakfı), Istanbul, Turkey

- Led a program supporting the integration and welfare of African students in Türkiye.

RESEARCH NETWORKS AND MEMBERSHIP

HUMAN-IT - COST Action 24167 | October 2026 - Present
Member, Working Group 3: Social Transformations, Policy and the New Job Market
Member of a European research network examining how AI and disruptive technologies are reshaping work and the job market. Contribute research on labour-market inclusion, skills, and digital transformation, using econometrics, machine learning, and causal inference.

Relevant study 1: Explainable machine learning research on informal employment in The Gambia examines how gender, livelihood strategies and location shape exclusion from formal work.

Relevant study 2: Ongoing research asks whether skills and job availability predict occupational transitions and destination occupations.

Proposed WG3 contribution: Develop a reproducible analytical framework linking workers' skills, available jobs and occupational transitions to identify groups at risk of exclusion as AI reshapes labour demand.

EDUCATION

- Financial Engineering studies, WorldQuant University, Washington, US | 2026 - ongoing
- PhD in Economics, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey | 2023 - ongoing
  Research focus: financial inclusion, digital finance, financial resilience, causal machine learning, and cross-country African microdata.
  Dissertation: FinTech and Financial Inclusion: Drivers, Resilience and the Digital Divide
  Supervisor: Asad Ul Islam Khan
- MA in Economics, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey | 2021 - 2023
  Specialisation: labor economics, panel data analysis, and applied econometrics
  Thesis: Examining the Relationship between Government Size and Unemployment: Evidence from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS)
  Supervisor: Şerife Genç İleri
- BSc in Business Administration, Anadolu University, Eskişehir, Turkey | 2019 - 2022
- BSc in Applied Mathematics, Bolu Abant Izzet Baysal University, Bolu, Turkey | 2017 - 2021

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- YADESA Summer School on AI-Enhanced Social Science Research, Ibn Haldun University 2026
- Course in Behavioural Finance, Duke University – through Coursera 2022
- Course in Economics of Money and Banking, Columbia University – through Coursera 2021
- Course in Financial Markets, Yale University – through Coursera 2021

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Savings finance, participation finance, and alternative financial institutions
- Financial inclusion, household finance, and financial resilience
- FinTech, digital financial services, and digital accessibility
- Consumer experience, institutional trust, and financial consumer protection
- Islamic finance and financial-sector development
- Applied econometrics, causal machine learning, and text analytics for policy analysis
- Labour markets, occupational mobility, skills, and job availability
- AI, disruptive technologies, digital transformation, and labour-market inclusion

PEER-REVIEWED JOURNAL ARTICLES

- Bekiroğlu, A. M, Saidy, S., Vergil, H., & Hassan, A. D. (2026). Islamic Finance Development and FinTech Innovation: Pathways to Financial Inclusion in OIC and Non-OIC Countries. International Journal of Islamic and Middle Eastern Finance and Management, (Q1, Scopus/SSCI). https://doi.org/10.1108/IMEFM-04-2026-0293
- Saidy, S. & Hassan A. D. (2026). Institutional Quality, FDI Effectiveness, and Economic Growth in The Gambia, SN Business & Economics 6, 241, (Q3, Scopus). https://doi.org/10.1007/s43546-026-01256-9
- Hassan A. D. & Saidy, S. (2026). The conflict-growth nexus in Fragile States: Empirical evidence from Somalia, International Journal of Social Sciences Perspectives 17(1), 25-35. https://doi.org/10.33094/ijssp.v17i1.2436

- Vergil, H. & Saidy, S. (2025). Examining foreign capital inflows and growth in The Gambia: A dual-gap approach, South African Journal of Economic and Management Sciences 28(1), (Q2, Scopus/SSCI indexed). https://doi.org/10.4102/sajems.v28i1.6031
- Saidy, S. & Hassan, A. D. (2025). Modelling drivers of fintech adoption in Sub-Saharan Africa using machine learning, Digit Finance 7, 1065-1091 (2025), (Q2, Scopus). https://doi.org/10.1007/s42521-025-00161-4

BOOK CHAPTERS

- Saidy, S. & Ibrahim, M. M. (2026). Law As a Buffer: Legal Gender Rights and the Inequality-Female Labor Force Participation Nexus in West Africa. In Makro İktisat Alanında Akademik Tartışmalar (pp. 178-199). YAZ Yayınları. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21333804
- Ibrahim, M. M. & Saidy, S. (2026). Material Deprivation and Gender Economic Norms in East Africa: Does Poverty Harden or Erode Attitudes on Women's Land and Employment Rights? In Mikro İktisat Alanında Akademik Tartışmalar (pp. 13-31). YAZ Yayınları. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21333948
- Saidy, S. & Genç İleri, Ş. (2024). Unveiling the impact of government size on labor markets in ECOWAS. Ş. Karabulut (Ed.), Makro İktisat Çalışmaları içinde (90-110 ss.). Afyonkarahisar: Yaz Yayınları. https://www.doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.12728565

CURRENT RESEARCH QUESTIONS

My ongoing research explores the following questions:

- How do people experience AI assistants, and what shapes satisfaction, trust and continued use?
- How does digital finance affect households' ability to cope with financial shocks, and who benefits most?
- How do the depth of financial inclusion and the quality of digital connectivity shape the use of digital financial services?
- When does digital access expand women's economic opportunities, and what barriers limit its benefits?
- How do gender, location and household circumstances shape access to formal employment?
- Do skills and job availability predict which workers change occupations, and where they go?
- How are AI and disruptive technologies reshaping labour-market inclusion?

CONFERENCES AND PUBLIC SEMINARS

- 3-6 June 2026 (conference dates) | Presented "Islamic Finance in the Digital Era: Translating Institutional Strength into Inclusive Outcomes," as part of interactive academic session "From Research to Impact" at the 3rd Global Islamic Economy Summit in Istanbul (Albaraka Summit 2026).
- 11-13 May 2026 (conference dates) | Presented "Informality as Structural Trap in The Gambia: Explainable Machine Learning Evidence on Gender, Livelihood Strategies, and Spatial Inequality," at the 3rd International Data Analytics and Machine Learning Conference (DATAMACLEA'26)
- 13 May 2026 | Presented "Can FinTech Build Financial Resilience? Causal Machine Learning Evidence from 35 African Countries," at the 9th Graduate Studies Conference (GradCon'9), Ibn Haldun University.
- 29 November 2024 | Delivered a seminar on "Foreign Capital Inflows and Growth in The Gambia: A Dual-Gap Approach". Seminar Series, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey. https://econ.ihu.edu.tr/en/foreign-capital-inflows-and-growth-in-the-gambia-a-dual-gap-approach
- 29 March 2024 | Delivered a seminar on "Labor Force Participation and Employment Patterns in The Gambia: A Gender Perspective". Seminar Series, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey. https://econ.ihu.edu.tr/en/labor-force-participation-and-employment-patterns-in-the-gambia-a-gender-perspective
- 2 May 2025 | Delivered a seminar on "Financial Inclusion, Borrowing Patterns and Health Financing: A SEM Perspective." Seminar Series, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey. https://econ.ihu.edu.tr/en/financial-incl-borrowing-patterns-and-health-financing-a-sem-perspective
- 24 October 2025 | Delivered a seminar on "Islamic Financial Development and Fintech Growth: Drivers of Inclusion?" Seminar Series, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey. https://econ.ihu.edu.tr/en/islamic-finance-development-and-fintech-growth

AWARDS AND RECOGNITIONS

- Best Participant Researcher Scholarship, 3rd Global Islamic Economy Summit (Albaraka Summit), Istanbul, 2026 – awarded a fully funded place at the 47th AlBaraka Symposium, Madinah.
- Best Research Idea Award (Group A), YADESA Summer School on AI-Enhanced Social Science Research, Ibn Haldun University, Istanbul, Turkey, 2026.
- PhD Scholarship, Türkiye Scholarships (Türkiye Bursları), 2023-Present.

LANGUAGES

English – fluent; Mandinka – native; Wolof – proficient; Turkish – working proficiency; Arabic – working knowledge.